



SUCCESS SKILL: COMPLEX COMMUNICATION

This rubric is aligned to the [NCIES literature review](#) on complex communication. The value proposition is a clear research-based definition of complex communication. This research-based rubric¹ is designed to provide useful, formative information that teachers can use to guide instruction and provide feedback to students. Students can use it to reflect on the quality of their complex communication. Student performance is described along a continuum. The design of the rubric focuses on the complexities of communication strategies needed in the context of project tasks; it is *not* designed to assess all foundational skills often addressed in English Language Arts curricula. Rubrics are provided by grade span, K-2, 3-5, and 6-12. The K-2 rubric includes both a teacher version and a version for primary students or early readers. Highlights from the National Center for Assessment's Literature Review are provided below. Research indicates that complex communication requires synthesizing interrelationships among reading, writing, speaking, and listening skills, the role of technology, and verbal and non-verbal proficiencies in various situations and cultures. The research-based definition of complex communication includes (Thompson, 2020, p.11):

- **Comprehension of information:** Understands, recognizes, and selects appropriate and compelling information and perspectives provided through various sources (e.g., close reading of texts and/or media, attention and adjustment to nonverbal cues, active listening of oral presentations and discussions).
- **Presentation of information and ideas:** Creates an engaging and appropriate message for the intended audience, task, and purpose, whether orally, in writing, through multimedia, or a combination of these modes; actively engages in discourse by expressing feelings, preferences, needs, and opinions in a way that considers others; and uses nonverbal communication (e.g., body language, gestures, voice) to reinforce or replace other forms of presentation.
- **Implementation of information and ideas:** Enhances comprehension, presentation, and sharing of content information through the thoughtful use of information communication technology (e.g., digital tools), which moves beyond superficial use.
- **Recognition of culture and differences:** Deliberately accounts for differing values, attitudes, beliefs, and behaviors found in different cultural and social backgrounds in communication.

Complex communication as a student success skill is related to critical thinking, creativity, collaboration, and self-direction. Communication may impact the demonstration of these other success skills. Inferences related to student mastery should consider these interconnections (Thompson, 2020).

Use Gold Standard PBL to explicitly teach and assess complex communication skills:

- **Design authentic, real-world projects that engage students in the application of complex communication skills for a purpose.** By engaging in Gold Standard PBL, students have to think critically about authentic topics, make connections to themselves and their community, and demonstrate both their thinking and learning through complex communication strategies that are appropriate for audience, purpose, and discipline. It is important for teachers to provide explicit instruction in the foundational domains of communication (reading, writing, speaking, and listening) for a variety of disciplinary-appropriate purposes and audiences.
- **Review and pilot test the rubric in local contexts to ensure it accurately reflects how students across socio-cultural contexts and conditions demonstrate complex communication competencies.** Instructional practices to build complex communication should take into account cultural differences (Thompson, 2020), value the varied language practices students bring into the classroom, and recognize the relationships between language and power dynamics ([Delpit, 1988](#)). Teachers should also know their own cultural lens and recognize how that may influence the interpretation of culturally and linguistically diverse student learning behaviors ([Hammond, 2013](#)).

¹ These rubrics were created by National Center for Improvement of Educational Assessment (Center for Assessment) in collaboration with PBLWorks. This version of the rubric integrates asset-based language based on the *Ready for Rigor: A Framework for Culturally Responsive Teaching* (Hammond, 2013).



Complex Communication: Grade 3-5

Complex Communication occurs when students: listen and read carefully to understand the message; explain thoughts and ideas through words, writing, and body language; use technology to enhance a message; and communicate effectively with people in diverse cultures and backgrounds.

DIMENSION	Student Communication			
	Select the column where most of the criteria describe what a student knows and can do independently.			
	BEGINNING	EMERGING	DEVELOPING	DEMONSTRATING
Integration and Sharing	• Shares the central idea and basic details about a topic/message from reading or listening • Uses limited vocabulary to explain the topic or message	• Shares basic details (gained from reading or listening) about a topic • Uses simple vocabulary to explain a topic or message	• Shares connections and/or inferences in an organized way about a topic/message using relevant details from reading or listening • Uses a combination of simple and descriptive/content-specific vocabulary to explain the topic or message	• Shares an analysis of a main message to interpret the meaning of what was read or heard about a topic • Uses precise and descriptive/content-specific vocabulary to enhance a topic or message.
Discussion or Presentation of Information	• Needs support presenting for the situation, purpose, or audience (e.g., formal/informal) • Uses some relevant non-verbal actions and verbal clarity to communicate ideas	• May need some guidance adjusting for the situation, purpose, or audience. • Demonstrates clear communication, aligning verbal and nonverbal cues with the message's intent	• Presents appropriately for the situation, purpose, or audience most of the time • Demonstrates clear communication and non-verbal cues that align with messages and most audience members	• Presents appropriately for the situation, purpose, or audience. • Consistently demonstrates aligned verbal and non-verbal communication to convey a clear message to diverse audiences
Implementation of Multimedia (when applicable)	• Uses digital tools or visuals to create a presentation that may not fit the topic or message	• Uses digital tools or visuals to create a presentation that restates the topic or message	• Uses digital tools or visuals to create a presentation that explains the topic or message	• Uses digital tools or visuals to create a presentation that enhances or clarifies the topic or message